



Long after the custodial staff came through and the lights in the tower turned off for the night, the vent cover above the baron's desk popped out and fell onto the rug with a muffled *thunk*. After a few moments, a white mink leapt from the open vent and somersaulted through the air, transforming and landing lightly on two human feet. Tisket von Tasket stood and tugged at her 'Sarcasm Is Just Another Service I Offer' T shirt until it felt like it fit properly again. She tucked the drawing of the building's vent schematics into a pocket of her yoga pants, swapping it for a small lockpick set. The comm in her ear crackled with static, then blared Gibraltar's panicked voice.

"Tisket, did you make it back in? Are you inside the baron's office?"

Tisket's pointed nose twitched in annoyance. "No. I fell into an oubliette. I'm still falling. I'm going to be falling forever."

"Can you repeat that?" Gibraltar asked. "Tisket, please report. Have you really fallen into an oubliette? If so, I really *need* to know details about this oubliette. Does anything stand out?"

"Falling forever through darkness and despair," Tisket said.

"She did not fall into an oubliette," Ranveig's voice cut in. "That would be improbable. This is more of Tisket's foolishness."

"This is the deepest oubliette I've ever fallen into," Tisket said. She went to the door of the baron's office, sat back on her heels, and started dismantling the mechanical lock components, so much nicer to play with than the electrical kind. Something stuck, so she yanked it hard, which made the lock emit a sad grinding noise, like longing or the beginning of winter.

"Ranveig, Maarika, do you have eyes on Tisket? Can you confirm the presence or absence of an oubliette?" Gibraltar asked.

"If I see a bottle that says 'drink me', I should drink it, right?" Tisket said, finally opening the door for Maarika and Ranveig. Maarika had her laptop bag slung over her shoulder, headset canted back and perched like a tiara on her shimmering black hair. Ranveig scowled and hefted her axe, resting the handle against one of her broad shoulders.